> propaganda; economic warfare; preventive direct action, including sabotage, anti-sabotage, demolition and evacuation measures; subversion against hostile states, including assistance to underground resistance movements, guerrillas and refugee liberation groups, and support of indigenous anti-Communist elements in threatened countries of the free world.[31]

During the 1950s and 1960s the agency undertook ‘covert action’ on an extensive scale. This included the subversion and overthrow of governments considered hostile to US interests in the developing world, notably those of Mohammed Mosaddeq in Iran in 1953 (instigated and co-organised by the British Secret Intelligence Service (SIS aka MI6) and Jacobo Arbenz in Guatemala in 1954.[32]

Regime change in Guatemala was engineered in a CIA-organised coup, involving elements of the army and using techniques of psychological warfare, including fake radio broadcasts that unnerved the Guatemalan army. President Eisenhower approved Operation PB Success on condition there would be no overt US involvement. The guiding principle was ‘plausible deniability.’ This was the doctrine designed to ensure Washington’s ‘hidden hand’ remained hidden, and the image of the United States (including its commitment to the principles of international law) remained untarnished. However, when the operation was in jeopardy, Eisenhower was persuaded by Allan Dulles to relax deniability. A handful of aircraft flown by CIA pilots were committed after the DCI told Eisenhower that without air intervention there was no chance of success. When Dulles said that even with the air strikes there was only a twenty per cent chance of success, Ike nevertheless gave the go-ahead.

The CIA did not see any contradiction in protecting the principles of liberal democracy by overthrowing democratically elected governments. In the Manichean world of the Cold War, ends frequently justified means. When Kennedy took office, covert action was embedded in US statecraft. It was a ‘quiet option,’ somewhere between diplomacy and force. For Kennedy, it was an attractive means of getting things done quickly and discreetly.